HAYDEN A. VEGA
haydenvega@ucsb.edu
Website: haydenvega.github.io

EDUCATION

University of California Santa Barbara | *B.A. Marine Science* | 2021-2025 | GPA: 3.96 **|** Highest Honors, Top 2.5%

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Bren School of Environmental Science & Management: *Santa Barbara, CA*
Researcher (January 2025 - Present)
- Compile fin measurements for 522 shark species to design finning vulnerability models

UCSB Ocean Recoveries Lab: *Santa Barbara, CA*
Undergraduate Researcher (January 2022 - Present)
- Led a project to characterize predation on coral reefs in French Polynesia
- Led a project to study the effect of fish-coral mutualisms on coral physiology in French Polynesia
- Led a project to predict ecosystem functions of California seaweeds using herbarium specimens

Bren School of Environmental Science & Management: *Santa Barbara, CA*
Data Research and Communication Outreach Intern (June 2022 - September 2022)
- Mapped whale entanglements and potential fishing exclusion zones in California
- Drafted media and communication materials to inform non-profits about marine debris

UCSB Cheadle Center for Biodiversity and Ecological Restoration: *Santa Barbara, CA*
Student Coordinator (August 2021 - March 2023)
- Trained and supervised volunteer invertebrate monitoring in Devereaux Slough

PUBLICATIONS

Vega, H., & Feitosa, L. M. (2025).A Complete Dataset of Shark Fin Morphometrics: A Machine Learning and Ecomorphological Approach. Dataset. Dryad. https://doi.org/10.5061/dryad.7h44j1081
(In prep) **Vega, H**., Osenberg, C., Seifert, A., Munk, N., Stier, A. Coral-Associated Fishes Accelerate Coral Wound Healing and Photosynthetic Recovery
(In prep) **Vega, H**., Feitosa, L.M., Gaines, S. Shark Finning Vulnerability: A Social-morphological Perspective
(In prep) Bui, A., **Vega, H**., A Stier. Macroalgal Herbarium Specimens Can Predict Historical Ecosystem Functions in Kelp Forests
(In prep) **Vega, H**., Stier, A. Data for Coral-Associated Fishes Accelerate Coral Wound Healing and Photosynthetic Recovery

PRESENTATIONS

H Vega. (2025). *Fish are friends and so are you!* Worster Symposium, Goleta, CA.
- Fifteen minute talk on work funded by the Worster Foundation and its impact on DEIJ

H Vega. (2025). *Coral-Associated Fishes Accelerate Coral Wound Healing and Photosynthetic Recovery*. UCSB Undergraduate Research Symposium, Goleta, CA.
- Fifteen minute talk on the role of coral-associated fish in coral lesion healing and recovery

H Vega. (2024). *Coral-Associated Fishes Accelerate Tissue Regeneration and Photosynthesis*. Western Society of Naturalists Conference, Portland, OR
- Fifteen minute talk on the role of coral-associated fishes in coral lesion healing and recovery

H Vega. (2022). *Approaches to DEIJ in environmental science.* Bren Mantell Symposium, Goleta, CA
- Panelist speaker about BIPOC experience and outreach in marine and environmental science

H Vega. (2022). *A Whale of a Problem: Mapping Fishing Debris*. Bren Mantell Symposium, Goleta, CA
- Poster on the locations of Southern California whale entanglements and marine debris

H Vega. (2021). Invert Monitoring at COPR. UC Undergraduate Research Symposium, Goleta, CA
- A fifteen minute talk on macroinvertebrate populations within brackish wetlands

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Marine Science Department, College of Creative Studies: *Santa Barbara, CA*
Teaching Assistant: MARINCS 101 (January 2025 - June 2025)

- Assist instruction of an introductory data science course in R

MEDIA & OUTREACH

Artist, **Coal Oil Point: A Seaweed Mosaic**, *UC Reserve System*, 2025
Featured, **Real-world coral studies spark future in ocean conservation**, The Current, 2025
Featured, **Hayden Vega: A First Generation, Triple Major Undergraduate**, *UC Santa Barbara*, 2025
Featured, **Extraordinary Paths: Celebrating CCS Class of 2025**, UCSB Creative Studies, 2025
Featured, **Blue Future: Citizen Science and Activism**, *Patagonia*, 2024
Co-author, **Diving in to REEF Safe Sunscreen: Meet the Scientists**, *Avasol*, 2023
Author, **ODA: Twenty Years of Debris Free Seas**, *Ocean Defenders Alliance*, 2022
Author, **Safe Boating and Fishing Practices**, *OC Coastkeeper*, 2020
Author, **How our Intern Brought Fishing Line Recycling to Seal Beach**, *OC Coastkeeper*, 2020

FELLOWSHIPS & AWARDS

Princeton EEB Scholar (2025)
STEMSEAS Oceanographic Fellow (2025)
UCSB Environmental Studies Academic Achievement Award (2025)
Honorable Mention: Best Fifteen Minute Talk, *UC Undergraduate Research Symposium* (2025)
Arnhold Climate Collaborative Fellow ($6000) (2025)
Schmidt Foundation Mentorship Award ($4500) (2025)
Worster Foundation Research Grant ($4500) (2024)
UCSB Career Catalyst Award ($2000) (2024)
College of Creative Studies Travel Grant ($1500) (2024)
UCSB Environmental Studies Research Grant ($1000) (2024)
Tom Rogers Scholar ($4500) (2024)
SACNAS - California Sea Grant Pathways to Inclusive Research Fellow (2023)
Shoreliner Scholar ($2500) (2023)
Tom Rogers Scholar ($4500) (2023)
Coastal Fund Research Grant ($12739) (2023)
DIVErsity in Diving Fellow (2022)
Bentson Scholar ($15000) (2022)
Bren Environmental Diversity Leaders Fellowship ($5000) (2022)
FUERTE Undergraduate Fellow (2022)
Hispanic Scholarship Scholar ($5000) (2021)

SERVICE

UCSB FUERTE Mentor *Santa Barbara, CA* (January 2024 - Present)

- Mentor undergraduate students from underrepresented backgrounds during field research experiences

UCSB Diversity in Diving Mentor *Santa Barbara, CA* (January 2023 - Present)

- Chaperone and support new divers as they complete their scientific diving certifications

Goleta Surfrider Foundation *Santa Barbara, CA* (October 2021 - June 2025)

- Sample and publish bacteria content of Santa Barbara beaches

Orange County Coastkeeper *Costa Mesa, CA* (August 2020 - September 2021)

- Draft blog reports about safe boating and angling practices

Seal Beach Fishing Line Recycling Program Founder, *Seal Beach, CA* (August 2020 - Present)

SKILLS

AAUS Diver, Rescue Diver, Nitrox Diver, CPR & First Aid, RStudio, ArcGIS, ImageJ, eDNA, French biliteracy